

FATak

A Three-Act Play

Julian

FADE IN:

ACT I

1 **EXT. FATAK'S STREET - AFTERNOON**

1

A narrow, sun-washed street. Scooters lean against compound walls. A pressure cooker whistles somewhere. The smell of fried onions, cardamom, cloves and chicken drifts through the air.

FATAK, 17, lively, restless, and perpetually hungry, sits on a doorstep with a cup of tea.

He takes a sip.

FATAK

My tea is getting cold.

He looks toward the house.

FATAK

Amma!

No answer.

FATAK

Amma!

AMMA, 45, appears at the doorway carrying a kitchen towel.

AMMA

What now?

FATAK

What are we having for lunch?

AMMA

Food.

FATAK

What food?

AMMA

The kind that disappears when you put it in your mouth.

FATAK

Amma.

AMMA

Biryani.

Fatak sits upright as though someone has switched on a lamp inside him.

FATAK
Chicken?

AMMA
Chicken.

FATAK
With potatoes?

AMMA
With potatoes.

FATAK
The big potatoes?

AMMA
There are no small potatoes in this house. You eat all the small ones first.

Fatak grins.

FATAK
I knew today would be a good day.

AMMA
Every day is a good day when you are not the one cooking.

Fatak takes another long sip of tea.

FATAK
I have been thinking.

AMMA
Dangerous.

FATAK
We should have biryani every day.

AMMA
That is not thinking. That is a stomach speaking through you.

FATAK
Imagine it. Every day. Lunch. Biryani.

AMMA
And dinner?

FATAK
Biryani.

AMMA
Breakfast?

FATAK

Tea.

AMMA

Only tea?

FATAK

Biryani would be strange at breakfast.

AMMA

Good. There is hope for civilization.

She disappears into the kitchen.

Fatak smiles into his tea.

CUT TO:

2 INT. FATAK'S HOUSE - LUNCHTIME

2

A steel plate of chicken biryani.

Fatak eats with full concentration.

He separates one potato. Smells it. Eats it.

He closes his eyes.

FATAK

Perfect.

His younger sister, LILI, 10, watches him.

LILI

You say that every day.

FATAK

Because every day it is true.

LILI

Doesn't it get boring?

FATAK

Does the moon get boring because it comes back every month?

LILI

The moon is not chicken.

FATAK

You are very young.

Lili steals a piece of chicken.

FATAK

Hey!

LILI

The moon shared.

Amma enters.

AMMA

Let her eat.

FATAK

She has her own food.

AMMA

And yet she is your sister.

Fatak reluctantly pushes another piece toward Lili.

LILI

See? He can share.

FATAK

One piece is sharing. Two pieces is charity. Three pieces is robbery.

They laugh.

A MONTAGE OF DAYS:

Fatak eats biryani.

Fatak drinks tea.

Fatak asks Amma about biryani.

Fatak carries a plate to the courtyard.

Fatak studies with the smell of biryani in the room.

Fatak works.

Biryani.

Tea.

Biryani.

The routine becomes almost ceremonial.

3 EXT. STREET - EVENING

3

Fatak and three friends play cricket with a battered tennis ball.

The friends are RIZWAN, 17, dramatic; MALA, 16, observant; and KIRAN, 18, always hungry but always joking.

RIZWAN

Run!

KIRAN

I am running!

MALA

You are walking!

KIRAN

I am preserving energy.

Rizwan hits the ball.

THWACK.

The ball flies over the neighboring wall.

Everyone groans.

RIZWAN

Fatak, your turn.

FATAK

Why me?

MALA

Because you are the one who said, "I can climb that wall."

FATAK

I said I could climb a wall. I did not say I wanted to.

KIRAN

Go, biryani prince.

FATAK

Do not call me that.

KIRAN

Why? It is accurate.

Fatak climbs the wall.

He drops into the neighboring compound.

4 EXT. NEIGHBORING COMPOUND - CONTINUOUS

4

A quiet corner.

An OLD MAN, KAREEM, 65, sits on the ground beside a dented metal bowl.

In it: a little plain rice. No meat. No gravy. No spice.

He eats slowly.

Fatak freezes.

The man looks up.

KAREEM
Looking for something?

FATAK
The ball.

Kareem points.

KAREEM
Behind you.

Fatak picks it up.

He cannot stop looking at the bowl.

KAREEM
It is only rice.

FATAK
I know.

KAREEM
Rice is also food.

FATAK
I know.

KAREEM
You look surprised.

FATAK
I suppose I am.

KAREEM
By the rice?

FATAK
By how little there is.

Kareem considers him.

KAREEM
You can have too much of a good
thing without noticing the little
that is enough.

Fatak doesn't know what to say.

KAREEM
Your friends are waiting.

Fatak nods.

FATAK

Yes.

He leaves.

5 **EXT. STREET - MOMENTS LATER**

5

Rizwan grabs the ball.

RIZWAN

What took you so long?

FATAK

Nothing.

MALA

You look strange.

FATAK

Do I?

KIRAN

Maybe you have finally run out of appetite.

Fatak watches the neighboring compound.

FATAK

Let's play.

They resume the game.

But Fatak is no longer playing.

His mind is elsewhere.

6 **INT. FATAK'S HOUSE - NIGHT**

6

Dinner.

Fatak barely touches his food.

AMMA

Are you ill?

FATAK

No.

LILI

Did someone die?

AMMA

Lili.

LILI

He looks like somebody died.

FATAK
Nobody died.

AMMA
Then eat.

Fatak eats one mouthful.

AMMA
Only one?

FATAK
Amma...

AMMA
Hmm?

FATAK
Do you think everyone eats like us?

Amma sits.

AMMA
No.

FATAK
Why?

AMMA
Because people are different.

FATAK
No. I mean... why should some people
have more than enough and others
have almost nothing?

Amma takes a breath.

AMMA
That is a question bigger than your
dinner plate.

FATAK
Maybe not.

Lili looks at him.

FATAK
Maybe it starts with the plate.

Silence.

ACT I END

ACT II

7 INT. FATAK'S HOUSE - NEXT DAY - AFTERNOON

7

The familiar ritual.

Biryani is served.

Fatak stares at it.

Amma waits.

AMMA

What is wrong with it?

FATAK

Nothing.

AMMA

Too much salt?

FATAK

No.

AMMA

Too little chicken?

FATAK

No.

AMMA

Then eat.

Fatak carefully divides the biryani into two portions.

Amma watches.

AMMA

What are you doing?

FATAK

Changing something.

AMMA

What?

FATAK

My share.

He eats half.

AMMA

And the other half?

FATAK

Tomorrow.

AMMA

It will not be biryani tomorrow.

FATAK

Then it will become tomorrow's problem.

AMMA

You cannot save tomorrow by starving today.

FATAK

I am not starving.

AMMA

You are sixteen steps away from a dramatic song about famine.

FATAK

I just want to eat less.

AMMA

Why?

FATAK

Because somewhere somebody is eating less because they have to.

Amma softens.

AMMA

And you think eating less will feed them?

FATAK

I don't know.

AMMA

Then what are you trying to do?

FATAK

Not pretend I don't know.

Amma sits beside him.

AMMA

That is a beginning.

8 **EXT. TEA STALL - EVENING**

8

Fatak sits with Rizwan, Mala, and Kiran.

A kettle whistles.

TEA SELLER

Four teas?

FATAK

Three.

Everyone looks at him.

KIRAN
Three?

FATAK
I am cutting down.

RIZWAN
On tea?

FATAK
A little.

KIRAN
This is serious.

MALA
What happened?

Fatak tells them about Kareem.

The jokes fade.

RIZWAN
So what will you do?

FATAK
Eat less.

KIRAN
That's it?

FATAK
For now.

MALA
That sounds like a private promise,
not a solution.

FATAK
Maybe private promises are where
solutions begin.

KIRAN
Or maybe you just want to lose
weight without admitting it.

Fatak smiles.

FATAK
I have seen you eat four samosas.

KIRAN
Research.

MALA

Research into what?

KIRAN

The structural integrity of the human stomach.

They laugh.

Then Mala gets serious.

MALA

If you really want to help, learn where the food goes.

FATAK

What do you mean?

MALA

Restaurants throw away food. Shops throw away food. Weddings throw away food. Houses throw away food.

FATAK

So what do we do?

MALA

Find out.

MONTAGE:

Fatak and his friends visit a small restaurant after closing.

They see unsold food being discarded.

A shopkeeper throws bruised vegetables into a bin.

Fatak carries leftover bread to Kareem.

Kareem refuses.

KAREEM

Do not turn me into a lesson.

FATAK

I am not.

KAREEM

Then don't bring me food to make yourself feel better.

Fatak is stunned.

KAREEM

Give it because you want another
(MORE)

KAREEM (CONT'D)

person to eat. Not because you want to become a good person.

FATAK

How do I know the difference?

KAREEM

You don't. That is why you keep checking yourself.

Fatak sits beside him.

They share silence.

9 INT. FATAK'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

9

Fatak catches Amma measuring rice.

FATAK

How much rice do we usually cook?

AMMA

Enough for everyone.

FATAK

That is not a number.

AMMA

It is the best number.

FATAK

Suppose we cooked less.

AMMA

Then suppose everyone remained hungry.

FATAK

What about leftovers?

AMMA

You have finally noticed them.

Fatak looks embarrassed.

AMMA

You think the promise is only about eating less.

FATAK

Isn't it?

AMMA

No. It is about wasting less of what you already have.

FATAK

So I should finish everything.

AMMA

Not everything. Only what you take.

A beat.

AMMA

The world does not become fair
because you leave food on a plate.

FATAK

Then what?

AMMA

The world becomes a little less
careless when you pay attention.

10 **EXT. COMMUNITY LANE - DAY**

10

Fatak and his friends put up a hand-painted sign:

TAKE WHAT YOU NEED. LEAVE WHAT YOU DON'T.

A skeptical NEIGHBOR, MR. SEN, 55, watches.

MR. SEN

What is this?

FATAK

A food shelf.

MR. SEN

Who gave you permission?

FATAK

No one.

MR. SEN

Then who takes responsibility?

FATAK

We do.

MR. SEN

You are children.

MALA

That is temporary.

Mr. Sen studies them.

MR. SEN

People will misuse it.

FATAK

Maybe.

MR. SEN

People will take more than they need.

FATAK

Maybe.

MR. SEN

People will laugh.

FATAK

Probably.

MR. SEN

Then why do it?

FATAK

Because there are already people with too little.

Mr. Sen has no immediate answer.

He puts a bag of rice on the shelf.

MR. SEN

For the record, I am doing this because my wife cooks too much.

MALA

Of course.

He walks away.

The shelf slowly fills.

Then it empties.

Again.

And again.

ACT II END

ACT III

11 EXT. COMMUNITY LANE - MONTHS LATER - MORNING

11

The food shelf has become a modest community pantry.

A hand-painted board reads:

FOOD FOR TODAY.

People come and go.

Fatak carries a sack of rice.

Kiran counts tins.

Rizwan repairs a shelf.

Mala keeps a notebook.

MALA

We served seventy-three portions
this week.

KIRAN

Seventy-four.

MALA

You ate one.

KIRAN

I was testing quality.

FATAK

You are very committed to public
service.

Kiran bows.

KAREEM enters.

He carries something wrapped in cloth.

KAREEM

For you.

Fatak opens it.

Inside is a small brass bowl.

FATAK

What's this?

KAREEM

My mother used it.

FATAK

I can't take it.

KAREEM

You can.

FATAK

Why?

KAREEM

Because a bowl should not sit empty
forever.

Fatak is moved.

KAREEM

And because you once looked at my rice as though it had broken your heart.

FATAK

It did.

KAREEM

Good.

FATAK

Good?

KAREEM

A heart that never breaks is not much use to anybody.

Amma arrives with a large pot.

AMMA

Move. Move. Move. Hot biryani.

Fatak's eyes widen.

KIRAN

The prince has returned.

FATAK

Don't call me that.

AMMA

I made enough for everyone.

FATAK

How much did you make?

AMMA

Enough.

FATAK

That's not a number.

AMMA

It is when you have been cooking for forty-five years.

Laughter.

They serve biryani to the people gathered.

Fatak takes a portion.

It is modest.

He sits beside Kareem.

KAREEM

You used to eat twice this much.

FATAK

I know.

KAREEM

Do you miss it?

Fatak looks at the plate.

FATAK

Sometimes.

KAREEM

Then eat it.

FATAK

What?

KAREEM

You made a promise not to eat more than you need. You did not promise to stop being hungry.

Fatak smiles.

He takes a bite.

KAREEM

Good?

FATAK

Perfect.

KAREEM

Doesn't it get boring?

Fatak looks at him.

FATAK

Never.

Across the lane, a CHILD watches the food.

Fatak notices.

He gestures.

FATAK

Come.

The child approaches.

Fatak moves his plate over.

The child takes a piece.

Fatak laughs.

FATAK

Take another.

The child does.

Fatak watches, not possessive now, but delighted.

MALA

Fatak.

FATAK

Hmm?

MALA

What do you think your promise
actually changed?

Fatak thinks.

FATAK

Me.

MALA

Only you?

Fatak looks around.

At the shelf.

At Amma.

At Kareem.

At the friends.

At the people eating.

FATAK

I don't know.

KAREEM

That is the right answer.

RIZWAN

But something changed.

KIRAN

Definitely my diet.

They laugh.

Fatak stands.

He walks toward the food shelf.

There is one empty basket.

He puts the brass bowl inside it.

FATAK

For whoever comes tomorrow.

Amma watches him.

AMMA

And what will you eat tomorrow?

Fatak smiles.

FATAK

Whatever is enough.

A breeze moves through the lane.

The sign above the shelf trembles:

FOOD FOR TODAY.

Fatak looks at it.

Then at the people.

Then at his half-eaten biryani.

He takes another bite.

BLACKOUT.

END.